Ch.9: Ethics and Environment

Kylie Lallak, Asise Bhinder, Neha Anadure, Hanson Lau, Mitee Su, Camila Orozco

9.1 Extending the Moral Sphere

- Jeremy Bentham, realized the importance of the treatment of animals
- Anthropomorphizing animals, the book describes as “treating them as through they were human” (page 120).
    - He talks about animal suffering, and the welfare of animals

Example: Punch, Japanese Baby Monkey

- Abandoned by his mother
- Other monkeys hit and drag him
- Internet says he’s getting “bullied” by other monkeys
- Zookeepers gave him a stuffed monkey animal, for comfort

9.1

Question in the book:

Are we justified in causing animals suffering for the purpose of human entertainment or the production of better cosmetic preparations? Why?

- Animals being used in Circuses, causing them to be weaker
- Bears on leashes
- Tigers in cages
- Elephants in captivity
- Animal testing in the cosmetics industry
- Draize Test
- LD50 Test

9.2 What Is Intrinsic Value?

Key idea:

Environmental ethics asks whether nature has value in itself, not just value for humans.

Two types of value:

Instrumental Value	**Intrinsic Value**
Something is valuable because it is useful Examples: trees → lumber rivers → drinking water animals → food	Something is valuable **in its own right**, even if it benefits no one.

If a beautiful rainforest exists where no humans will ever go, does it still have value?

Does a dress that has had work into designing and being styled that stays on a mannequin in the show window still have value?

Does a painting in a locked room still has value even if nobody sees it?

Yes or no?

The Traditional View of Nature

Historically, most ethical theories treated nature as instrumentally valuable.
Meaning: Nature matters because it helps humans survive or prosper.

Examples: forests -> resources, animals -> agriculture, land -> economic production

Problem the book raises:

If nature only matters for human benefit, then destroying forests, driving species extinct, and polluting ecosystems might be acceptable if humans benefit.

If a company profits from destroying a forest, is it morally wrong?

The Difficulty of Intrinsic Value

Question raised:

How do we decide what has intrinsic value?

Possible answers: only humans, humans + animals, all living things, entire ecosystems

Each choice leads to different moral rules.

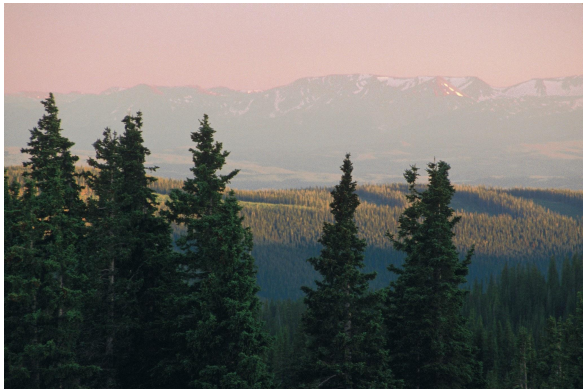
Example scenario:

If all living things have intrinsic value, is cutting down a tree wrong? Is farming immoral?

If mosquitoes have intrinsic value, should we stop killing them?

Shrinking Wilderness

- The “Wilderness” is defined as any area on Earth free of human habitation or activity



- This stretches from land to ocean

- The Wilderness is “a resource which can shrink but not grow” (Leopold, 1949)

Why do we care?

- These untouched areas often hold potential for human use, such sources for minerals and natural resources

Why should we forgo these benefits to preserve wilderness?

Is protecting land for its "natural beauty" just another human-centered value?

Takeaway

- Conservationists want to protect nature so it stays independent and untouched by humans

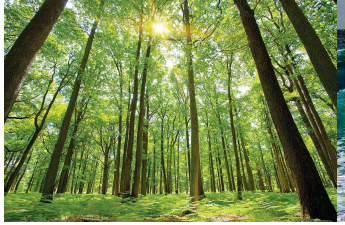
- To protect these areas, humans have to create policies, make borders and actively manage them

- The act of preserving wilderness is human influence meaning the attempt to save nature is still a form of human control

The Lorax

- The Once-ler
  - Greed
  - Deforestation
  - Ignored the warnings of the Lorax and continued to cut down Truffula trees for personal gains
  - In turn, damaged the ecosystem
    - No more trees, no more Thneeds
  - The animals that depended and resided in the trees lost their homes and way of life
  - Realization only after his business plummeted, started to care after facing the consequences
- Ted Wiggins
  - Wanted to find trees to impress his crush
    - Initially started as selfish reason
  - As he heard more of the Once-ler's story, started to see why Audrey cared
  - Wanted to help bring back the trees and animals that once lived there
    - Transition from personal interest to concern for all living things
  - Saw the bigger picture, cared less about impressing Audrey and more about bringing back the trees + air

Connection to Wilderness Perspective



- Concern for wildlife stems from human assigned value
  - Not inherent, depends on what humans decide to care about
- Can genuine care about the environment exist without stemming from personal gain/selfishness?
  - Ex: Caring about biodiversity/pollution/endangered species only because the collapse of an ecosystem ends up affecting us
  - Lorax: Humans cared only because decreasing air quality which personally affected them
    - No more trees, clean air, water
  - Vs: Caring regardless of its effect on us because these are living beings too
- Can humans care about the environment (plants, animals, etc) if it doesn't affect us?
  - Personally: No, we are interconnected and we all affect each other. Impossible to answer this question because we are not separate, there is always cause and effect, so caring for the environment inevitable means caring about ourselves

9.6 Nature and Gaia

- Gaia hypothesis formulated by James Lovelock
  - “Earth is a dynamic physiological system that regulates global climate and chemistry” (Graham, 130)
- Connection to deep ecology
  - Respect for Gaia and seeing it as more important than humans seen as basis for deep ecology
- *Promethean fear*
  - “A fear of taking too lightly or inconsiderately our relations to nature” (Graham, 129)
  - Earth’s hypothesized powers of self-regulation and recovery warrant this fear
- *The Revenge of Gaia*
  - Lovelock warns of floods, famine, etc. that threaten humanity
  - Worries about humans, says Gaia might be weakened but will survive (shallow ecology)
- Environmentalism and religion
  - Lovelock speaks about human hubris and humanity’s “sin” against the environment
  - This moves beyond the ethical, away from moral to spiritual and resembles Abrahamic faiths

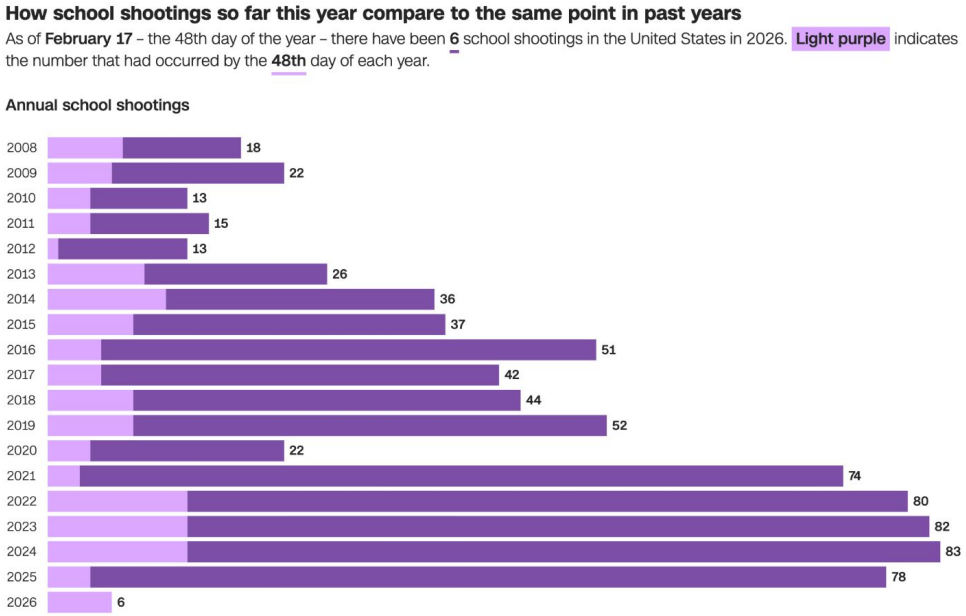
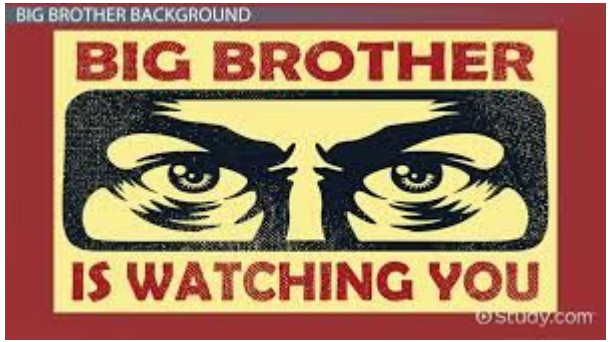
Avatar and Eywa

- *Avatar* set on moon called Pandora
- Eywa is sentient, biological, and spiritual deity of Pandora
  - Serves as a massive neural network connecting all living beings
- Eywa acts as guiding force to maintain ecosystem equilibrium
  - Often acts to defend Pandora when necessary to keep balanced ecosystem
- Worshipped as a goddess

Consensus Chapter 5

5.3 - “Privacy must be the inalienable right of every citizen, rooted in their rightful autonomy”

Privacy vs Safety

- about 88% had at least one social media account and 76% posted disturbing content (such as guns or threatening messages) before their attack.
- Most offenders show some interest in violence; through movies, video games, books, or social media :
- Most attackers engaged in some behavior prior an incident that caused others concern

Would you be okay with loss of privacy if it was guaranteed to ensure your physical safety?